- Finance approvers may view budget and billing information but not modify project settings.

Since project roles are provided as verifiable credentials, C³ does not need to maintain a role directory or account store for each tenant's customers and partners. The role lifecycle remains under the tenant's control. When a participant's assignment changes or the project ends, the tenant updates or revokes the credential, and C³ automatically reflects those changes. This enables ACME to provide a secure, flexible collaboration environment without involving itself in every tenant's identity and access management processes.

16.9 Operational and governance considerations

Integrating verifiable credentials into authorization involves more than just protocol support or policy design. It requires operational discipline and governance structures that ensure the system behaves predictably as issuers, credentials, and workflows evolve. The same principles that guided ACME's use of contextual signals in chapter 12, such as freshness, trust, confidence, and controlled distribution, are also applicable here. Verifiable credentials broaden ACME's context surface, and with that expansion comes the need to carefully manage how issuers are assessed, how credentials are verified, and how exceptions are handled.

16.9.1 Deciding when to use verifiable credentials

Verifiable credentials aren't necessarily a substitute for every type of identity integration. They are most effective when any of the following apply:

- **Authority resides outside ACME.** When another organization is the primary authority for employment, licensure, delegation, or certification VCs make the most sense.
- **Participants change frequently.** Short-lived collaborations, rotating teams, and external contractors benefit most from credential-based access.
- **Cross-organization access is the norm.** Federation works well with a small number of partners; VCs scale to many.